

Speaker 1: I will introduce myself quickly, present the name of the research, and then we'll start the interview. I am [Name], I am an [occupation], I am in the [1st-5th] semester, and this research is part of a laboratory of research and social changes. This research is about the quality of relationships, it's a study that is running in some countries, five countries, and the original researcher is from the Philippines. That's it, okay? Okay. Great, let's start with the questions. First, I'd like to know how old you are, please.

Speaker 2: I will be, well, I am [46-50].

Speaker 1: Great, you don't have to answer anything you don't want to, you can just ask me to skip to the next question, okay?

Speaker 2: Okay.

Speaker 1: So, how long have you and your husband been together?

Speaker 2: [21-25] years.

Speaker 1: I was telling him, I am turning [21-25] today, so your relationship time is my age, and that is very cool.

Speaker 2: Yeah, a long time.

Speaker 1: And do you have children?

Speaker 2: Yes, [1-5].

Speaker 1: [1-5] children, and you all live together, the [1-5] children, you, and [Partner's Name]?

Speaker 2: The eldest no longer lives with us, she is [21-25] years old.

Speaker 1: So you live with [Partner's Name] and [1-5] children?

Speaker 2: Yes, we have a [16-20]-year-old pair of twins.

Speaker 1: That's nice. Boy and girl? Wow, that's cool, that's cool.

And I would like to know what your profession is and your main source of income, whether it comes from your profession or from [Partner's Name] or from your children?

Speaker 2: Look, we help each other. [Partner's Name] has had a lot of health problems lately, a motorcycle accident, so over the last [1-5] years many things have gotten worse, and I finished a [course] in [department] to go back to work because I dedicated many years to my children and to him as well, because he is like a child, honestly. He is one of your children, another child. An old one.

Speaker 1: I understand, I understand. Have you seen that internet meme about which child causes the most trouble? The one from my mother-in-law.

Speaker 2: Exactly.

Speaker 1: Understood.

Speaker 2: Okay, and can I call [Partner's Name] by his name and your husband? Can I use both terms?

Speaker 2: Sure.

Speaker 1: I would like you to tell me your story, how you met, your love story, how your relationship began.

Speaker 2: Well, at the beginning, I had just arrived in [Country], and I had little time here, less than [1-5] year, I think. And everything was very expensive, so I found a place to live, which was a boarding house, and there we met because I was going down some stairs, carrying bags, and he asked if I needed help, and I said yes. He helped me, I thanked him, and that's how we met because the ground floor was for women only and upstairs was for men. I ended up meeting him and other people who lived there. Our story started that way, but I was in another relationship at that time. I fell in love with him, ended the other relationship, and I am older than him. That's how it was, he was very young, he had just turned [16-20].

Speaker 1: Understood. And was your other relationship also in [Country]?

Speaker 2: Yes, but it was just a boyfriend, a real boyfriend. I never lived with anyone else.

Speaker 1: Understood. And now a question to compare, how do you compare your relationship with [Partner's Name] to the relationships of people around you? Friends, family, do you think your relationship is of higher or lower quality compared to others?

Speaker 2: Look, we have few couple friends because we are very homebodies. I see that some couples are similar to us, and others are very bad.

Speaker 1: Understood. So, compared to couples with low-quality relationships, yours is higher quality.

Speaker 2: Yes.

Speaker 1: Okay. And how do you compare your current relationship with previous ones? You mentioned the other boyfriend, but if you've had others, how do you compare those relationships?

Speaker 2: Look, what I can say is just things from when we were dating. With him, I can speak about [21-25] years of living together, which is very different. When you start living with someone, it doesn't matter if you're officially married or not, it's very complicated.

Speaker 1: It's different, right? So, dating is completely different from a [21-25]-year marriage with children.

Speaker 2: With children, with everything, the conflicts, the differences. Because when we date, we know a person in one way, and it doesn't stay that way. Sometimes, even now, we think it is one way, but it's not. People change constantly, all the time, and we have to deal with that daily, which impacts a relationship a lot.

Speaker 1: And for you, what makes your relationship high or low quality? You consider your relationship to have good quality, so what makes it of good quality?

Speaker 2: Look, today I think we are okay, in the sense that we are calm, children are grown, everything is on track, but the relationship itself, it's good, but today we are much more friends than romantic partners, you know? He doesn't talk much, he doesn't converse, while I talk, argue, and yell when necessary. But he doesn't, he is more reserved. He should be more proactive, not needing to be asked.

Speaker 1: Because, as you said, you shouldn't be his mother.

Speaker 2: Exactly. Someone who shares the same responsibilities, so no one needs to keep asking the other. He would say that I changed his life a lot because when I met him, I was [21-25], and he was [16-20], so the mindset of a [21-25]-year-old is very different. Compared to [16-20], yes. Especially for a man, they are more childish than women, I think. I had to take the lead, and it was always like that, me leading everything. The relationship was very good for many years, even with the kids growing up and everything. Of course, every couple argues, but today we are much more peaceful. Very peaceful indeed.

Speaker 1: And for you, what is the most important thing in a relationship? Is it love, companionship, financial issues? What is most important to you, in your view?

Speaker 2: I think companionship, because financial issues can be overcome. We work, get unemployed, it's okay, it's a phase, but we pursue jobs. Today, I can manage to help at home with daily jobs, with extras on weekends and holidays.

Speaker 1: So, is companionship above love for you? Or are love and companionship the same thing?

Speaker 2: No, they are not the same. I think that over the years, you really start to love in a different way. But there is no doubt that love is much greater, in a different form, not like before. As I said, love is different from passion. It is not just that feeling you have in the first years.

Speaker 1: Got it. So, the next question is already about this. For you, what does love mean?

Speaker 2: Wow. Difficult.

Speaker 1: Take your time.

Speaker 2: It's very difficult to answer. But I think love is the most beautiful thing that exists. And I lived that for many years, love in a different form. Love is when you listen to the person. When you are always there. When you can count on them. When there is affection. Sorry, I get emotional.

Speaker 1: No, it's okay, it's okay. You can get emotional, we can move on to the next question if you prefer.

Speaker 2: It's okay. It's all these things together, you know? Companionship, affection you have. And I miss a lot of things.

Speaker 1: You can say what you miss, it's okay.

Speaker 2: Everything changes. You try to make things better because you can't live in a house without presence. Love exists, but you need more. If you are present. And I miss that a lot. Now, I see that I spent many years with family. When you go out, you see a different world, and you think, I want this. I want to go out, I want to be able to have fun more. Because we, as [occupation], have many limitations. [Occupation], [occupation], all that. I am a very overwhelmed person. As I said, I am always leading everything. And it's bad. It's very bad. We should be side by side, or he should lead a bit more, at least.

Speaker 1: That makes sense. It must be very tiring because, in addition to being a mother, doing household chores, and having your job and studies, you got a job in the [department]. So, I understand it's a lot, a lot indeed. So, it's really tough.

Speaker 2: And I finished the college project yesterday. My God. He got very sick on Monday, it was very difficult. I said, I couldn't, we were at the doctor, and all the preparation, a lot of rush, clothes, organizing, gift baskets. Each one did their part. So, it was very hectic. And also worrying about him because he has dengue.

Speaker 1: Yes, but congratulations on finishing it.

Speaker 2: Wow, it ended perfectly because I was very tense, but at the moment, everything went well.

Speaker 1: You knew, and at the moment, you just managed to deliver. But it's good that it worked out.

Speaker 2: Thank you.

Speaker 1: You're welcome. The next question is about love in the relationship. For example, some people believe that love doesn't sustain a relationship, but others believe that a relationship can only sustain with love. So, for you, how important is love for maintaining a quality relationship?

Speaker 2: I think love is very important within a relationship. But, it alone doesn't sustain. It doesn't because, in my mind, there are other factors. For example, I think, today, I am more supportive of us two than he is. I believe in that. I don't know what he thinks. I know what he said, but I believe that I am. In the sense of wanting to improve, seek solutions, and do something for the relationship. Yes, because he doesn't do that. He doesn't. He is a good person, respects me. I believe that outside, I don't know, but he is very homey, very family-oriented, no vices, he had them before, but not anymore for many years. Thank God. But I think I have fought much more for the relationship.

Speaker 1: And even with love, maybe these things wear out the relationship. Even with love, it's not enough because there are other things that weigh much more.

Speaker 2: Much more. Believe me, much more.

Speaker 1: I understand. The next question is, how do you know and believe that [Partner's Name] loves you? What does he do to make you sure he loves you?

Speaker 2: If he does nothing, I can't say that, but that's the problem. I think he should love me the same way, like I would say, how I love today, but it's in a way. It's not that carnal love anymore. I don't know how to explain this to you.

Speaker 1: I think I get it. Let me try to externalize so you can understand, that love of building a life together. Having a family, things together, and you love each other for the whole journey. And also because you reach an age where it can't just be carnal. There are couples who reach an age where they stay together because they love each other, but also that passion you mentioned, the difference between passion and love. Does it make sense what I said?

Speaker 2: Yes. And also, he doesn't do anything to make things happen, to improve. Nothing different, like, let's do it this way, what do you want me to do, what's happening. And when you lower your guard and let it go, let it go.

Speaker 1: And the next question is about challenges and conflicts. What challenges and conflicts do you face in the relationship? You said there aren't many arguments, but what is the biggest conflict and challenge for you?

Speaker 2: The biggest conflict is that he didn't grow mentally. That's the biggest conflict. Stuck on the same point. I think as time passes, we also need to grow mentally. We need to react differently. It's not that he is irresponsible, but he needs to act with more maturity. More firm actions, decisions, talking.

Speaker 1: And does this happen very frequently then? It's a frequent challenge.

Speaker 2: Yes.

Speaker 1: Okay, you already answered many, so I'm skipping some because you already said a lot, and the questions repeat. And how do you resolve it, for example, when he acts

immaturely, you talk, and how do you resolve it? Do you stay silent, wait for it to pass, what happens?

Speaker 2: For a long time, I tried, in the past, when we were younger, we argued. I spoke louder, all that, but that was a long time ago. But he doesn't talk. He doesn't talk. He doesn't talk.

Speaker 1: Yes, I see, it's a challenge, not talking is a big challenge.

Speaker 2: He doesn't talk, doesn't want to know. Ah, let's start talking about it, what's going on. Then he shuts down, you know?

Speaker 1: And it seems like he doesn't want to talk. You call to talk, and he doesn't want to.

Speaker 2: No.

Speaker 1: And what strategy do you use to resolve this, for example? If he doesn't want to talk, do you leave him alone, don't talk, accept that he doesn't want to, or do you insist or give up?

Speaker 2: I insisted a lot before. Today, I don't anymore. I don't.

Speaker 1: I see. And would you say that your relationship is good for you? And why?

Speaker 2: It's not good. Not anymore. It stopped being good. It stopped being good.

Speaker 1: And why did it stop being good? And when did it stop being good? Did something specific happen?

Speaker 2: I think. As I mentioned, I feel very overwhelmed, always having to be at the forefront of everything, always dealing with problems, and trying to solve them. This ends up wearing me out a lot. That is one of the biggest reasons for all of this.

Speaker 1: Do you believe that your relationship has changed you in any way? Have you become more or less of something because of it, and what was that change?

Speaker: I have learned to see both sides of life, in the sense of the before and the after of everything until now. So, the before is better. I think today, with the age I have, if I had to start all over again, I wouldn't. I love my family. I love my children. They are wonderful, truly wonderful. They don't give me any trouble. They are my pride, very proud of them. In fact, I have two girls at the university. One is studying [field].

Speaker 1: Oh, how nice!

Speaker 2: I don't know if he mentioned this at any point. But one studies [department]. The other studies French.

Speaker 1: That's cool!

Speaker 2: The boy is also in college, but not at the university. But he is in college.

Speaker 1: Oh, that's nice. That's really nice.

Speaker 2: It's a source of great pride.

Speaker 1: Yes, yes. And do you believe that your relationship changed [Partner's Name] in any way? Did he become a different person after starting a relationship with you?

Speaker 2: He became a better person. I have no doubt. Much better. In the sense of wanting to build a different life. But not just that. He had many problems when I met him, many issues. My goodness, it would be very tough to tell. And I managed to help him a lot. I was always there for him in difficult times. He changed a lot. He improved. You might think it's contradictory because, at the same time, I say something negative, but he did change. The responsibility among his four siblings, he is the only one who managed to reach a certain level. He is doing well. He has an organized life. We have a car. I have my own car that he bought. And we have well-raised children, a good education, something we didn't have much of. Neither he nor I. But we did everything for the kids. Oh, kids. They are adults now.

Speaker 1: But to a mother, they are always children. There's no way. Mothers don't accept it. They are always kids.

Speaker 2: We call them babies.

Speaker 1: Next question. Do you feel secure in your relationship?

Speaker 2: I do.

Speaker 1: And why? What gives you this sense of security?

Speaker 2: In the way we live today. He is always present. As I said, he is present but not present. It's like, I know he's here.

Speaker 1: Alright, I thought my internet had dropped.

Speaker 2: It didn't.

Speaker 1: I will show you the screen. A scale from one to nine will appear. I will read a statement, and you will tell me how true that statement is for you. Let me just show the screen. It will appear soon. Can you see it?

Speaker 2: It's very small.

Speaker 1: Let me enlarge it here.

Speaker 2: Okay, I'm enlarging it. Not true at all, somewhat true, more or less true, very true, or completely true.

Speaker 1: The statement is, "My partner really listens to me." How true is this for you?

Speaker 2: Does he listen to me?

Speaker 1: Does he listen to you?

Speaker 2: Very true.

Speaker 1: Very true?

Speaker 2: Yes.

Speaker 1: What does he do that makes you know he really listens to you?

Speaker 2: When I give advice, I tell him not to do something because it won't be good for him. And he listens and follows my advice. He always says, "You said no, so it must be no."

Speaker 1: Got it. The same dynamic but with another statement. "My partner cares about my needs." On a scale of one to nine, how true is this?

Speaker 2: Today, he doesn't care much. I will give him a five. He says he cares, but he doesn't.

Speaker 1: Does this relate to what you said about him not noticing things and not doing them on his own?

Speaker 2: Yes, exactly. When it comes to needs, you shouldn't have to keep telling the person. They should understand and act on their own. Exactly.

Speaker 1: I will stop sharing the screen. It should stop appearing now.

Speaker 2: I think it has.

Speaker 1: Now, I will ask two questions about your sex life. If you don't want to answer, you don't have to. It's okay?

Speaker 2: Alright.

Speaker 1: The first question is, have you had sexual relations recently?

Speaker 2: No. Recently, like in the last [1-5] years. I will tell you. In the last [1-5] years, we have had many problems, mainly with him. And I think it affects him a lot psychologically. He had a [accident], two strokes. In addition, there was an assault at our house. He was shot in the chest. [1-5] years ago, on [Department]. So, it's been a lot over the last [1-5] years. It has

shaken him and me a lot. So, we have focused more on his health because he has many limitations now, many problems. So, I think, in his mind, it has become a last priority.

Speaker 1: I understand. The second question on this topic is, are you satisfied with your sex life, and why?

Speaker 2: I am not. I wish it was better. But in this period, I think all these things ended up being left aside. Over the last [1-5] years, it became less frequent, the desire diminished.

Speaker 1: I understand.

Speaker 2: I am not happy about it. I believe he isn't either. But he doesn't want to talk about it.

Speaker 1: It's funny because to resume a sexual life, you need to talk. Preferences might change, and with each one's difficulties, it's necessary to discuss how things will work. You can't just show up and do it without talking.

Speaker 2: Yes.

Speaker 1: And even talking about it already triggers libido. So, it's the beginning of something happening, and it's important to talk.

Speaker 2: True.

Speaker 1: Sorry.

Speaker 2: No problem at all.

Speaker 1: Alright then. I will show you something else on the screen, and you will have to choose an option. I will show it now. And I will ask you a question. The question is, how satisfied are you with your relationship in general? Considering everything you have told me, everything you know in your heart, how satisfied are you overall? From completely dissatisfied to completely satisfied. Just tell me which one you choose.

Speaker 2: A little dissatisfied. No doubt.

Speaker 1: Okay, got it. And now, the last question of the interview. You mentioned being a little dissatisfied. Evaluating your response, how little dissatisfied are you? Is it 100% a little dissatisfied or 50% a little dissatisfied? It's a confusing question.

Speaker 2: Yes, but I understand. 50%.

Speaker 1: Okay. And why do you feel that way?

Speaker 2: I think. No, I don't think, I am sure. Because of the things he can't do. He should be more proactive in everything. He should take more care of our lives, more than just doing the

minimum. After everything that happened, I think we should travel more, go out a bit, explore new places. We don't do that.

Speaker 1: Even going for a coffee at a bakery is different from having coffee at home. It helps.

Speaker 2: It helps. True. In that sense, you know, taking better care of things. He is a very good person. Very good. He has always dedicated himself entirely until now. I have even considered that other people wouldn't have the patience for him. I think it's time to follow your path. But he doesn't... He is very calm. He never said anything to me. I wish he would talk more about everything, you know? Let's analyze things from the beginning until now. What am I doing that you don't like anymore? What is missing? Let's try to restart in a different way. Restart in the sense that, after [21-25] years together, everything has obviously changed. Mentally and physically, I am not the same either. So, as I said, try to change in the sense of having more dialogue, more initiative... Firmness.

Speaker 1: Yes.

Speaker 2: How we say in the [Location], "Pulso firme". I am from the [Location] of [Country] and that's what my father from [Location] says. He says that too.

Speaker 1: Ana, thank you. That was the interview. I enjoyed interviewing you and talking to you. Thank you for your time and availability.

Speaker 2: I appreciate it very much. It was good because talking a little helps. For me, it was great. You have no idea how much.

Speaker 1: That's great, [Name]. Thank you very much. I will just stop the recording, and then we can end the call. Okay?